

practice and problem solving. Five product categories were tested, including desktop PCs, notebook PCs, servers, judges' touch screens and printers.

d How many Lenovo technicians are working at the Games, and how do you prepare them for something of this scale?

Xie: We have a core team of more than 10 experienced technology professionals who managed the systems at the Torino Games (2006 Winter Games), and dozens of other technicians and engineers who gained invaluable experience there. These experts, along with the rest of the nearly 600-person engineering team, have been involved in training classes for the past few months, where every one of them is trained on operating the PCs and printers to be used at Games. A sub-group was set up that will focus on servers which require an added layer of expertise, and these people received additional training.

The team has so far put in many thousands of man hours of technical services and support through the Good Luck Beijing sporting events and technical rehearsals. Their training involved both classroom lessons and hands-on testing in real-life situations.

d How big a role do you have in worldwide broadcasting of the Games?

Xie: Lenovo is involved in the broadcast in several ways. First and foremost, Lenovo will provide 2,000 touch screen displays as part of the Commentator Information System. Media personalities will use these touch-screens to access the Commentator Information System during their broadcasts to get up to the minute biographical and statistical information about any athlete or team. In addition, Lenovo works directly with some of the broadcasters to provide equipment for their on-site operations.

Perfect Timing

Do we really need to tell you what Omega is famous for? They're the official timekeepers for the Games, and with world records sometimes being bested by a millisecond or two, you can bet on how important their job is. Taking a race as an example, Omega has systems attached to the starter's gun, cameras to monitor false starters, and photo-finish cameras at the finish. They also have about 450 employees on-site at the games, 70 of those huge public scoreboards, over 300 smaller scoreboards, and an overall 420 tonnes of equipment—175 km of optical fibre and cables, and 65 generators.

Over the years, Omega has developed a device called Scan'O'Vision, which is a photo-finish camera that is connected to photoelectric cells to click pictures as soon as some part of an athlete's body crosses the finish line. The

technology has been fine-tuned to be able to provide a picture within seconds of the race finishing—very important to please today's impatient TV viewers. It's not just the finish, but also the start of the race that is monitored. Omega builds speakers into each starting block, so that all athletes hear the starter pistol at the exact same time. It also has sensors built into the starting blocks to help calculate the time between the starter pistol being fired (which also has a sensor attached to it) and the athlete reacting. Reactions are gauged by the pressure the athlete exerts on the starting block, and software calculates the acceptable human

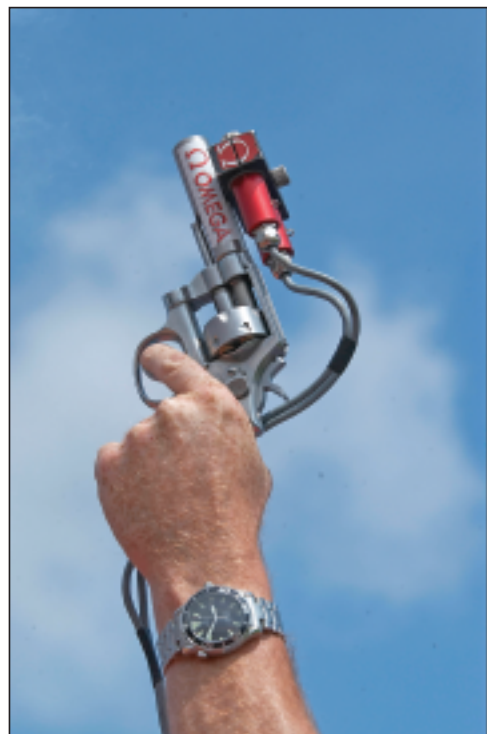
response time to the pistol. If the athlete begins his race even a fraction of a second faster than what is considered an acceptable reaction time, he or she is penalised for a false start, and the race restarted.

Omega is also responsible for measuring distances—for events such as long jump, shot put, javelin, etc. There's no tape used these days; it's all laser measurement, which is extremely precise. Lastly, Omega has also spent a lot of time modifying their scoreboards to display all letters of the Chinese alphabet—which we know is no small feat.

Enjoy!

We wish we could go into more details about the Games and the technology that runs them, but we might never be able to stop. We've tried to give you an idea of how big of a feat it really is to manage the biggest sporting event on the planet, but to be honest, we've probably only scratched the surface at best. However, if possible, while you sit at home and grab your couch handles in excitement as some of the most exciting athletic competitions take place at Beijing 2008, try not to forget the thousands of men and women behind the scenes who are slogging day and night to ensure that everything at the Games works as well as one of Omega's ridiculously expensive masterpieces. Let's give them all a standing ovation and a medal, we say. ☒

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Omega's starter gun—apart from a sensor to record the exact instant the gun is fired, there's also a mic to carry sound to the speakers on starting blocks

“I run to be known as the greatest runner, the greatest of all time. I could not eat or sleep for a week after I lost in the [1992] Olympics. I have to win or die.”

Noureddine Morceli

The Famous Algerian athlete, at the 1996 Summer Olympics